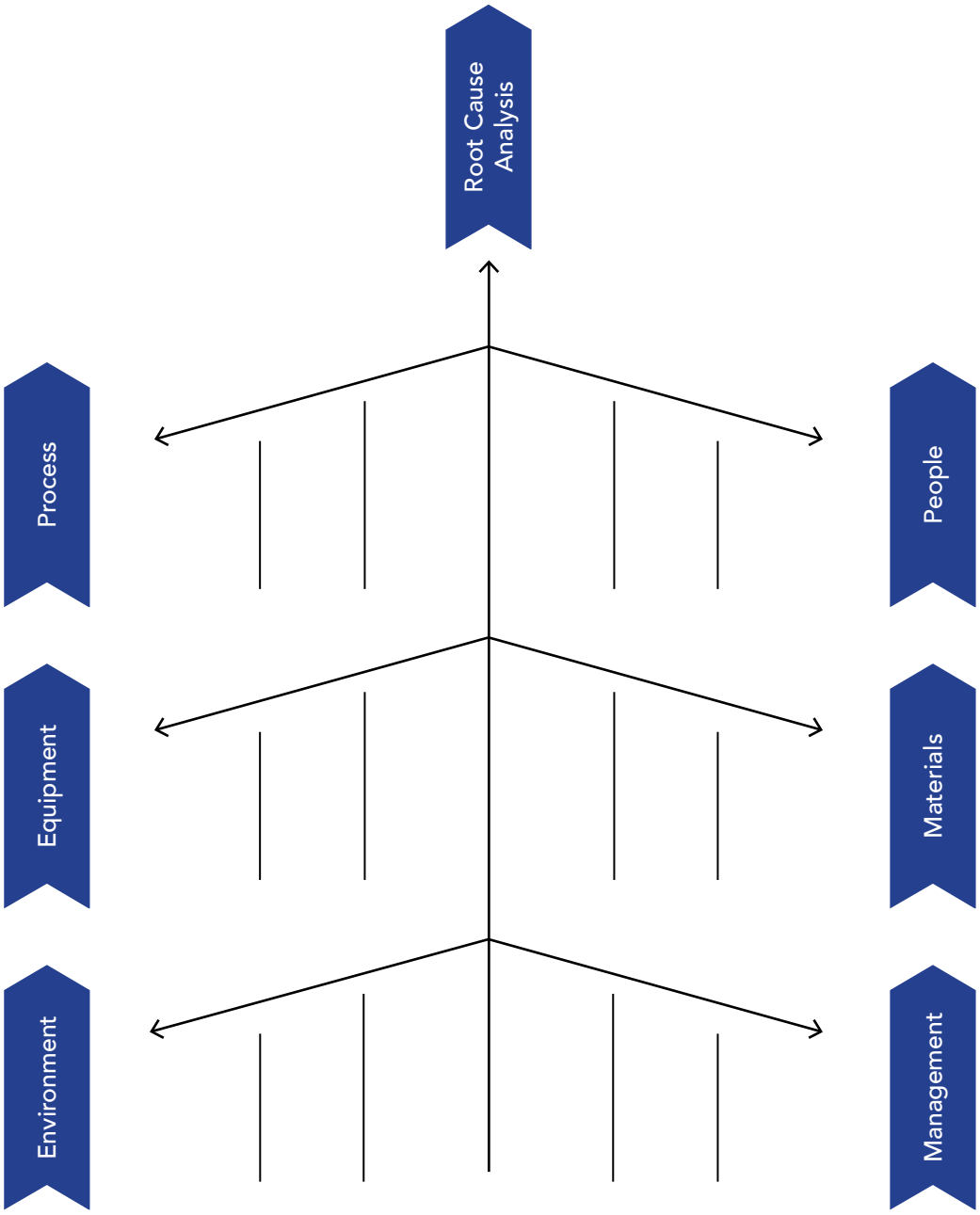
Handout 1

Fishbone Diagram Template



Handout 2

Five Whys Template

Problem:

Why?

Why?

Why?

Why?

Why?

Root Cause:

Lesson Plan #3:
Effective Workplace Emails (Writing Focus)



This lesson is part of a Tourism Pathways training program, which prepares participants for entry-level roles in the tourism sector. Many of the training participants are newcomers to Canada and English language learners.



Under represented Groups

This lesson is delivered near the beginning of the training to introduce the writing focus for the program: how to write an effective workplace email.

Time: 1.5 hours

Materials & Resources

- Presentation slides: Email Best Practices
- Handouts: 1. Parts of an Email
  2. Sample Email
  3. Formal & Informal Language
- Tech: Digital device with email capabilities

Pre-requisite Knowledge & Skills

Participants need to have a working email address and the ability to use a digital device to send an email, or this instruction must be front-loaded. This lesson can be adapted to a variety of writing abilities (by adjusting the complexity of the email scenarios), but participants need to be able to write basic sentences.

Virtual Delivery Tips

This lesson can be delivered in-person or virtually. Here are a few ideas to adapt the lesson for a virtual audience:

- Digital Materials: Ensure all presentation slides and handouts are available digitally for participants to access during the virtual session. Share the materials via email or through a learning management system before the class.
- Interactive Discussions: Use virtual platforms to facilitate opening discussions about when to write emails in the workplace. Encourage participants to share their ideas through features like chat or audio sharing.

- Small Group Activities: Organize virtual breakout rooms for small group discussions on email best practices.
- Screen Sharing: Utilize screen sharing to present the parts of an email and sample emails. Guide participants through labeling the parts of a sample email and debrief the answers as a whole class.
- Virtual Comparisons: Use a learning management system for participants to post and share their email writing. Participants can provide peer feedback to one another.
- Social-Emotional Learning: Integrate instruction on effective collaboration skills to support participants' social-emotional learning. Discuss how collaboration and teamwork might be similar or different in an online context.

Skill Components

This lesson focuses primarily on Writing Components #4 and #5.

Writing Components

1. Identify the task that requires you to write
   - Identify the goals and purposes of the writing task

4. Choose the appropriate language and style for the writing task
   - Use formal and informal tone and language appropriate for audience and context

5. Choose the appropriate format for the writing task
   - To organize information or ideas, use paragraphs, bullet points, numbered list, subheadings, etc.
   - Use pre-determined or pre-formatted workplace documents

6. Review and revise your writing
   - Proofread and correct your writing for grammar and spelling
   - Proofread and revise your writing for accuracy, meaning, and tone

Research Report to Support the Launch for Skills for Success (p. 17)

Digital Components

2. Use common digital tools to complete tasks
   - Use software, mobile applications, and other digital tools for a purpose
   - Select appropriate digital tools based on your goals and purposes of tasks

5. Apply safe and responsible practices online
   - Protect personal information and privacy of yourself and others
   - Use appropriate language and behaviour online

Research Report to Support the Launch for Skills for Success (p. 21)

LESSON ACTIVITIES	
1	*Opening discussion* In which situations at work would you write an email? (e.g., running late, sick, to switch shifts, when it's best to document something). In which situations would you NOT write an email? (e.g., when you're angry/upset, personal matters, anything unprofessional, things that are difficult to explain) Ask participants to share their ideas.
2	*Activate background knowledge* In small groups, ask participants to make a "Top 10" list of email best practices and tips. Participants discuss then report back to the class. Presentation Slides: Then follow-up with practitioner-led instruction on email best practices, using the earlier discussion to recognize their prior knowledge, highlight new information and emphasize important concepts. (e.g., respond in a timely manner, acknowledge all emails, use email to document important communications, maintain a professional tone, keep it brief, proofread carefully before sending)
3	*Handout 1&2* Provide participants with a handout that defines the parts of an email (e.g., subject line, salutation, purpose, action items, sign-off). Then ask them to label the parts of a sample email. Debrief the answers.
4	*Discuss* What are the differences between formal and informal writing styles? In which situations at work or in life do you use each style? Present different examples of formal and informal writing to compare the two approaches.

LESSON ACTIVITIES	
5	*Handout 3* Provide sample sentences or emails that participants need to change to be more formal or informal depending on the given context.
6	*Practice* Ask participants to send you an email in response to a workplace scenario. Position yourself as their supervisor so that there is an element of authority and formality to consider (e.g., they are emailing their supervisor because they're sick and can't come to work). Remind participants to include the typical parts of an email and to pay attention to appropriate tone. Ask participants for permission to share their emails and give feedback next class.

Follow-up

Next lesson, debrief the email writing activity. Create a slide deck to present examples from some of the participant emails you received. Try to pull out examples of best practices and a few examples of what to avoid. Compare different approaches and ask participants to choose which subject line, greeting, closing, etc. is most effective and why.

Continue to provide practice opportunities throughout the training program. Consider asking participants to write emails in small groups, which encourages idea sharing and fosters teamwork and mentorship opportunities between stronger and weaker writers. Provide instruction on effective collaboration skills to support their social-emotional learning.



Handout 1

Parts of an Email

Use the following guidelines to write emails in your training and career.

Emails typically include the following eight parts:	
1. Recipient's email address	This is the email address of the person you are writing to. *Tip*: Wait to type the recipient's email address until you are finished writing and proofreading your email. This avoids accidentally sending an incomplete email.
2. Subject line	The subject line tells the reader what the email is about. A specific subject line lets the recipient quickly prioritize and find emails. Example: "Vacation request: August 5 to 9" or "Last minute client cancellation."
3. Salutation	Start by addressing the person you are writing to. Use a formal or informal style depending on your relationship with the recipient. For example: "Dear Mr. Peters:" or "Hello Joanna,"
4. Pleasantry	Open your email with a quick greeting or friendly remark. For example: "It was good to meet you at [event]," "Thank you for sending me the files," or "I trust your week is off to a good start."
5. Purpose	State the reason you are writing in the first paragraph. The purpose of your email should be immediately clear. Example: "I am writing to submit my application for the full-time housekeeping position" or "I would like to update my phone number on file."
6. Action items	Put any questions, requests, or instructions in a separate paragraph so that the recipient does not miss them. For several items, consider using a bulleted or numbered list.
7. Closing message	Finish your email with a polite closing, such as "Thank you for all your help with this," "Please let me know if you have any questions," or "I'm looking forward to hearing from you."
8. Sign-off	Choose an appropriate formal or informal sign-off to your email: "Best wishes," "Kind regards," or "Thanks,". Follow your sign-off with your name.



Handout 2

Sample Email

Label the eight parts in the email below.

New Message
To: pkwan@hotelmountainview.ca
Subject: Job offer for part-time housekeeping
Dear Ms. Kwan: It is nice to hear from you. I would like to accept the offer of a part-time housekeeping position at Hotel Mountainview. I am excited to join the team and begin working in my new career. Would you kindly let me know the next steps in terms of paperwork and training? I am available to start as soon as possible. Thank you for this opportunity. I look forward to working with you. Sincerely, Alice Phagoora
Send



Handout 3

Formal and Informal Language

When you write an email, you need to decide whether to use a formal or informal style. Your decision depends on your purpose for writing and the relationship you have with the person who receives your message.

For example, an email to apply for a job will be more formal than an email to arrange a coffee date. Likewise, an email to your friend will be more casual than an email to your boss.

Formal - serious and proper
Informal - relaxed and casual

Formal language is less personal than informal language. It emphasizes respect and politeness. Informal language is friendly and familiar. The table below compares examples of the two styles.

	Formal	Informal
Context	Business, legal, academic, professional	Personal, casual
Salutation	Dear Mr./Mrs./Ms. Wong: Dear Human Resources Manager: To Whom it May Concern:	Dear Sophia, Hi Mohammad, Hey Dad!
Contractions	I am writing to ask if you have… (Write words out in full)	I'm writing to ask if you've… (Contractions are okay)
Requests	Would you be able to complete it by Friday? Could you see if the parts have been ordered? Would you happen to know…?	Can you have it done by Friday? Have the parts been ordered? Do you know…?
Vocabulary	I would like to request some assistance. Once I have received the information from our suppliers, I will respond to your email. Unfortunately, I will not be able to… I would like to apologize for any inconvenience caused.	I'd like to ask for some help. After I hear back from the suppliers, I'll get back to you. I can't… Sorry for any trouble I caused.
Sign-off	Sincerely, Regards,	Thanks, Bye for now,

Practice

Rewrite the sentences below to be more formal and appropriate for the given context.

1) **An email job application with your résumé attached:** Here is my résumé.

2) **An email to a potential employer:** Actually, I am busy at 2pm now. Can we change the interview to 3pm instead?

3) **An email to follow-up an interview:** It's been a week. Did you hire someone?

4) **An email to your supervisor:** I'm sick. I can't work today.

5) **An email to your co-worker:** Hey, I can't work this Friday. Can you switch shifts with me? Thx.

6) **An email to a client:** Sorry, I messed up the schedule. It won't happen again!

Professional Development Opportunities

This is a list of courses and workshops from across Canada that are relevant to Skills for Success practitioners.

Note: The links provided here are for informational purposes only and do not constitute endorsement or recommendation. Please contact training organizations directly for more information.

1. Alberta Workforce Essential Skills: Practitioner Training

https://awes.ca/what-we-offer/training/

The essential skills framework can be challenging to learn on your own. AWES teaches you what it all means and how to use it to support your learners and clients. Workshops are designed for developing a comprehensive applied knowledge of workplace essential skills. We can customize workshops to meet the specific needs of your organization and the clients you serve. The following are some examples of the training AWES has developed.

- Foundations in Workplace Essential Skills
- WES for Specific Groups
- Advanced Practitioner Training – Working Effectively with Employers
- Advanced Practitioner Training – Conducting Needs Assessments.

2. Bow Valley College: The Test of Workplace Essential Skills (TOWES)

http://www.towes.com/en/products-and-services/professional-development--administrator-certification/professional-development--administrator-training-overview

TOWES offers a variety of presentations, professional development workshops and administrator certification programs for instructors, trainers, recruiters or those who just want to learn more about literacy and essential skills.

Programs are offered in-house at Bow Valley College, onsite at your organization, or at conference and training facilities located across the country. Many of our professional development programs and certification programs can be completed online or delivered remotely using web-based technology.

3. Douglas College: Aboriginal Essential Skills Journey Planting the Seeds for Growth

https://www.douglascollege.ca/programs-courses/training-group/skills-successessential-skills/practitioner-training-certificate-0

Introducing an Aboriginal Essential Skills workshop resource designed to introduce Essential Skills to front line workers, educators and trainers. This two day workshop toolkit includes a Facilitator's Guide and Participant Workbook.

4. Douglas College: Essential Skills Practitioner Training Certificate

https://www.douglascollege.ca/programs-courses/training-group/skills-successessential-skills/practitioner-training-certificate

The Essential Skills Practitioner Training (ESPT) Certificate Program is a unique six course program offered through online and face-to-face or hybrid formats.

The ESPT program is designed to assist individuals to integrate HRSDC's task based Essential Skills into the work that they do with learners. The courses help workers to understand and interpret Essential Skills Assessments and how to design activities that take a construct approach to build on learners existing skills.

5. SkillPlan: Customized Practitioner Workshops

https://skillplan.ca/services/

Educators will develop Skills for Success expertise with our in-depth workshops. These on-site or off-site workshops are ideal for workplace educators, adult educators, curriculum developers and project managers. Available by request, these workshops are offered as individual courses, combined courses and modified courses that focus on specific topics of interest.

A combination of these workshops may be used for customization:

- Controlling Complexity
- Document Use at the Workplace
- Skills for Success in the Workplace
- Essential Skills Job Profiling
- Needs Analysis
- Workplace Materials Development

6. Workplace Education Manitoba: Skills for Success Workplace Practitioner Certificate

https://workplaceconnections.ca/certification/

The Skills for Success Workplace Practitioner Certification Program is specifically designed to highlight the foundational and functional skills and abilities required to best serve the educational needs of learners, to support optimal learning, and to enhance organizations overall.

Skills for Success Practitioners are encouraged to engage in professional growth by also considering the strategic competencies needed to make an impact beyond the learning environment.

As part of the Practitioner Certification Program, Practitioners also achieve a Certificate in Relational Skills and have the ability to deliver customized relational skills to organizations across Canada.

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